The spurt in refrigerator and washing machine purchases came from replacement buyers, or those looking to upgrade, contributing almost 50 per cent to sales. In these categories, too, the demand was the highest for models with higher capacity, improved technology or simply better looks. Refrigerators, for example, saw maximum demand in 550- and 670-litre models. "Frost-free refrigerators," says Nandi of Godrej, "grew at 35-40 per cent from FY20 to FY23, while single-door ones grew only at 7-8 per cent. This growth is mirrored in washing machines, too, where fully automatic and front-loading versions grew at 39 per cent."

Sales of premium products peaked in the recently concluded festival season. Panasonic's refrigerators saw a 53 per cent growth in the side-by-side category (550+ litres), while their recently launched bottom-mounted refrigerators (357-401-litres) clocked a 126 per cent rise in the 350+ litre segment this time compared to the last festive season, according to Sandeep Sehgal, director, home appliances, Panasonic Life Solutions India. Premium and glass lid semi-automatic machines also registered a 45 per cent increase compared to the same time last year. New-age categories, such as dishwashers and high-end microwaves, are also recording tremendous growth, partly because of their small base, as Nandi of Godrej reveals. Catering to the lifestyle of the aspirational youth, Godrej launched a 30-litre small refrigerator, Qube Personal Cooling Solution, in 2019.

The increasing penetration of the Internet and smartphones is also pushing consumers to buy appliances with smart technologies. Sehgal of Panasonic tells us how their IoT-enabled platform MirAIe, available as an app on smartphones, allows their consumers to remotely access their ACs, TVs, washing machines, refrigerators, home automation systems, power plugs, fans and doorbells. Since its launch in 2020, over 350,000 customers have downloaded the app and 72 per cent use it to control the temperature of the ACs, while 17 per cent use it to operate their washing machines.

Audio equipment manufacturer JBL reports a spurt in demand for their high-end products, such as Soundbars, Partybox and Speakers, by those who crave a theatre-like experience at home. "The luxury audio business now accounts for approximately five per cent of HARMAN's overall consumer audio portfolio," says Vikram Kher, vice-president, lifestyle, HARMAN India. Grooming and self-care was another segment that flourished during the pandemic and continues to see brisk business. "During Covid, grooming and self-care moved from the salon to home, leading to the realisation that, with the available technology, a lot of grooming and styling could be done from the convenience of one's home," says Deepali Agarwal, business head, personal health, Philips Indian Subcontinent. Their Heated Straightening Brush, designed for working women pressed for time, is seeing a rise in sales upwards of 50 per cent year on year.





ABHISHEK KAPOOR
Group CEO, Puravankara

"BUYERS TODAY WANT TO UPGRADE THEIR COMMUNITY AND LIVING EXPERIENCE. TECHNOLOGY, COMMUNITY-BUILDING AND AMENITIES HAVE BECOME IMPORTANT"

Likewise, men's grooming rituals have become more elaborate over the years, involving facial hair, skin and body care. The onset of early puberty means boys are now beginning to shave early. And where, in the past, even the well-heeled would start their grooming journey with a three-blade razor, now they go for an All-in-One trimmer for the face, head and body, which costs Rs 4,500.

A significant reason why the premiumisation trend is booming in the consumer durables sector is the availability